

moved easily and quickly up and down the scale of political centralisation, with little disruption of their lives. These are all crucial notions in a continent where historical sources, excessively relied on, give us a confusing picture of skirmishes, tribute and vassality but little understanding of the workings of those principles.

I take S. McIntosh's point in her preface that it would be difficult to 'satisfy everyone's wish list for gender, national, ethnic, and disciplinary diversity' (p. ix), but I regret that the book does not contain any more contributions from African scholars. Of thirteen papers, eleven are by North American researchers. Also, work by historians, such as Fuglestad's research on multi-layered networks of authority in Hausa towns, which argues the importance of considering horizontal stratification and spiritual power, could have been integrated.

But the contributors make their point convincingly and forcefully. The fundamental problem with the evolutionary model is that it portrays societies as static and orders them hierarchically. Rather than successive stages, we should be talking of overlapping spheres: parallel groups within a society wielding different sorts of authority; politics of differential complexity in relation with each other. The reader is left with a greater awareness of the danger of mental biases, and with the feeling that the African continent has a genuine contribution to make in exploring the variability of human organisation.

ANNE HAOUR
St Cross College, Oxford

DAVID ELTIS, *The Rise of African Slavery in the Americas*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000, 368 pp., £37.50, ISBN 0 521 65231 6 (hard covers), £13.95, ISBN 0 521 65548 X (paperback).

This extremely readable, scholarly and original book is powerful evidence of the great strides that have been taken in the historical study of the Atlantic slave trade. There has been broad agreement for decades that the forced migration of millions of Africans across the Atlantic was not only one of the most tragic but also one of the most important processes in modern world history. But historians came at the subject from several directions which seemed to defy integration. Scholars of European maritime history were so immersed in quantitative data that they appeared to have little interest in the nature of the human victims of the process; in such literature Africa was a largely monolithic, unvarying labour pool. Those interested in African-American history wrote increasingly rich accounts of the very varied histories of people of African descent in the Americas but tended to construct a similarly timeless and unitary Africa which was first and last the source of 'African retentions'. Historians of Africa sought to understand the crucial relationship between 'traditional' forms of servitude and the demands of the trans-Saharan and Atlantic slave trades but seldom crossed the Atlantic—or the Mediterranean—to evaluate the consequences of the processes whose beginnings they had elaborated. It was another book from Cambridge University Press, John Thornton's remarkable *Africa and Africans in the making of the Atlantic world* (1992), which brought together the study of the importance of the slave trade in not one but three continents and in the course of which he gave real substance to a new region of world history, the Atlantic.

David Eltis, whose work on the economic history of the slave trade has enjoyed great respect for many years, takes these new developments even further in this fine new book. It synthesises the complex work of Americanists,

maritime historians and Africanists to come up with some conclusions which transform the field. As well as a great respect for the primary material, his is a very sophisticated reading of an extremely large corpus of scholarship; students will benefit for many years from his comprehensive bibliography and his scrupulous footnoting throughout, and the book is a real *vade mecum* in this respect. Once the large amount of evidence from Africa is imaginatively interwoven into the wider field, Africans emerge not only as victims but also as agents whose actions played a major role in determining the actual nature of that pernicious trade. The underlying message is that it was African political and economic strength which determined the limits to the intentions of merchants and planters. In turn it was the patchwork of African strengths and weaknesses over time and space which ordained the ethnic basis of those who were to be the ancestors of modern African-Americans.

Eltis's book should be read alongside the result of a major project in which he has played a crucial role. Cambridge University Press has recently issued the extraordinary CD-ROM database *The Atlantic Slave Trade*, edited by David Eltis, Stephen D. Behrendt, David Richardson and Herbert Klein, which provides, cheaply and accessibly, a thorough compilation of the records of the slave trade from its beginnings to the middle of the nineteenth century. The CD-ROM, which surely if incidentally constitutes the largest collection of data on pre-colonial Africa that is currently available, is in some senses the raw material upon which Eltis's book is built. Together they take the study of the slave trade into an entirely new era in which the complexity of Africa's past, which previously tended to be marginalised, plays, at long last, a central role in this extended and tragic moment in the making of the modern world. David Eltis has made us all his debtor by the publication of this major book and by his editorial role in the CD-ROM edition.

RICHARD RATHBONE

School of Oriental and African Studies, London

DIANE FROST, *Work and Community among West African Migrant Workers since the Nineteenth Century*, Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 1999, £32.00, 278 pp., ISBN 0 85323 523 6 (hard covers), £15.95, ISBN 0 85323 533 3 (paperback).

This work is the result of research for a doctoral thesis completed in 1992; thus it represents research probably completed some nine years before publication. Yet there is no evidence that the publishers asked Dr Frost to rewrite in the light of more recent publications; it is thus out of date, at least as far as work on African seamen and African settlers in Liverpool is concerned. The book also suffers from a lack of competent editing.

The author argues that the Kru seamen of her study, Liberian migrants settled in Sierra Leone, some of whom subsequently settled in Liverpool, are unique because of their 'twice migrant' status. But so were many Lascars, for example, who had migrated from inland cities to Indian ports in search of work and eventually settled in Britain; and many Caribbeans had work experience in Central and North America before migrating to Britain. Neither were the Kru the only settlers to 'initially maintain a transient status': most of the early post-war Caribbean migrants only intended to stay long enough to accumulate sufficient funds to set themselves up in business, etc., back home.

What are the book's merits? Almost half the book is devoted to the history of the migration of the Kru from Liberia, their settlement and history in Sierra Leone. We learn, for example, that the Europeans on the west coast associated